



Combat Mindset Conditioning

AN ARMY TRAINING PRODUCT WITHIN THE ARMY COMBAT MINDSET SYSTEM

Army Command School

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Purpose

Combat Mindset Conditioning (CMC) is the deliberate practice of an individual's capacity to regulate and sustain effective performance under operational pressure. It provides a structured method for developing Combat Mindset.

Combat Mindset: the capacity to regulate and sustain effective performance under operational pressure.

CMC is nested within the Army Combat Mindset System (ACMS) and supports its developmental pathway: **Understand Self → Regulate Self → Perform Under Pressure → Combat Mindset.**

Its purpose is not simply to teach individuals about pressure. It is to progressively condition the capacity to recognise, regulate and sustain performance as pressure and operational demands increase.

Working Terminology

CMC is derived from COGCON. If it is to be an Army product rather than COGCON delivered under another logo, its vocabulary should cohere with the ACMS. The substance of COGCON's architecture is preserved; the question is whether each label becomes Army language. The first four translations below are proposed; the remainder are working terms and not yet locked.

COGCON term	CMC working term	Status
COGCON	Combat Mindset Conditioning (CMC)	Proposed
COG6, the six cognitive pillars	Combat Mindset Training Pillars	Proposed
Operational Reset Tool	Combat Mindset Reset (CMR)	Proposed
OPS4, the Operational Performance States	Combat Mindset Performance States	Proposed
COGCON Coach	CMC Coach	Working
COGCON Level 1 and Level 2	CMC Coach and CMC Lead Coach	Working
Master COGCON Doctrine	CMC Training Doctrine, or CMC Training Standard	Working

Together these give CMC a coherent vocabulary: **Pillars → Reset → States → Methodology → Assurance.** In plain terms: what we develop, what we do when it drops, what we observe, how we train it, and how we maintain the standard.

1. Combat Mindset Training Pillars

CMC develops the underlying capacities required to maintain performance under pressure. The initial architecture draws directly from the six COGCON pillars, which COGCON treats as interdependent capacities in a deliberate sequence: self-awareness and arousal control are the foundation for downstream cognitive performance.

Pillar	What it develops
Self-Awareness	Recognise changes in physiological, cognitive and emotional state.
Arousal Control	Regulate physiological activation to maintain access to effective performance.
Operational Habit	Develop effective responses that remain available as conscious capacity reduces under pressure.
Working Memory	Retain and manipulate relevant information while operating under load.
Attentional Control	Direct, maintain and shift attention appropriately despite distraction, pressure and threat.
Cognitive Control	Inhibit ineffective responses and retain deliberate control over behaviour and decisions.

The collective construct is renamed; the individual pillars are not renamed mechanically. COGCON holds that the pillars and their sequencing are part of the underlying mechanism rather than arbitrary categories, so the substance is preserved first and the language reviewed second. Several names, such as Self-Awareness, Working Memory and Attentional Control, may already be adequate for Army use.

- **Army design requirement:** with Ken Franks, confirm whether each pillar needs an Army-facing name, and whether the set is adopted directly, consolidated or supplemented.

2. Combat Mindset Reset

Combat Mindset Reset (CMR): a simple, repeatable method for restoring regulation and effective performance under pressure.

The Reset gives the individual a short sequence that can be employed independently and under load:

Recognise → Regulate → Reorient → Re-engage. In use it should be as plain as "Recognise the drop. Combat Mindset Reset. Re-engage."

The Reset is derived from COGCON's Operational Reset Tool, whose mechanism incorporates appraisal of state, perceptual reorientation, physiological modulation and re-anchoring attention onto the next relevant action. The detailed sequence is retained within the COGCON Master Doctrine and accredited coaching material. COGCON's internal terminology for the mechanism need not be exposed at Army level: the mechanism can remain substantially derived from COGCON while the Army-facing construct is the Combat Mindset Reset.

- **Army design requirement:** work with Ken Franks to develop or adapt the Army-owned Reset and its terminology within the agreed IP arrangements.

3. Combat Mindset Performance States

CMC requires performance to be observable under pressure, not simply understood theoretically. The Performance States are the observable behavioural expression of the underlying regulation capacity. They answer a direct instructor question, "what does Combat Mindset look like?", with "we observe it through the Combat Mindset Performance States."

Performance state	Observable indicators	Note
Task Focus	Task focus and deliberate action.	Proposed Army label for COGCON's Performance Mindset.
Command Presence	Controlled posture, communication and pacing.	COGCON name retained.
Situational Awareness	Active scanning, information gathering and resistance to fixation.	COGCON name retained.
Resilience	Rapid recovery following error, correction or performance disruption.	COGCON name retained.

Command Presence, Situational Awareness and Resilience are already readily understood Army concepts. Performance Mindset is the one label scrutinised: alongside Combat Mindset and Performance Under Pressure it is one "mindset" too many, and COGCON notes it was chosen internally to avoid collision with Army's umbrella term. Task Focus is the cleaner behavioural label.

- **Army design requirement:** confirm the four states and their behavioural markers. They may be derived from OPS4 but should describe the behaviours Army expects to observe from its people under operational pressure.

4. CMC Training Methodology

CMC is conditioning through deliberate practice, not simply education about stress or cognition. Training progresses from understanding and practising the component skills in controlled conditions toward their application under increasingly representative pressure: **Learn → Practise → Pressure → Apply → Reinforce.**

Pressure is introduced progressively through physical, cognitive, emotional, environmental and task demands appropriate to the training context.

CMC does not need to exist solely as a standalone course. Once foundational skills have been taught, they can be deliberately practised and reinforced within existing Army training. COGCON argues explicitly for this approach: conditioning should occur within existing training, under the load that training already generates, rather than remaining a separate classroom activity. This allows CMC to be reinforced through PT, leadership training, field exercises and other individual and collective training as the system matures. The ACMS already anticipates this model of deliberate instruction followed by continued practice and application.

5. CMC Coaching and Assurance

CMC uses trained coaches and instructors to **observe → identify → intervene → reset → reassess.** Assessment focuses on whether the individual can demonstrate the required behaviours while under appropriate pressure, rather than simply recalling CMC knowledge.

COGCON provides a useful starting model: Level 1 Coach, Level 2 Coach and Specialist, supported by observed assessment, recertification and quality assurance. The working CMC equivalents are CMC Coach and CMC Lead Coach. CMC does not necessarily need to replicate COGCON's tiers.

CMC should be capable of both formal instruction and distributed reinforcement. Initially, specialist CMC instructors deliver foundational training and develop Army instructor capability. As proficiency develops, trained instructors and commanders reinforce CMC through existing training environments.

A defined assurance system protects: **training sequence · instructor competence · pressure progression · Reset integrity · behavioural standards · assessment consistency.** This is an area where COGCON gives Army a significant head start: its existing architecture already contains coach accreditation, recertification, quality assurance and drift control.

- **Army design requirement:** determine a coach and instructor model that fits existing Army instructor qualification, assurance and training-management systems.

6. Progressive Development

CMC directly supports the four-stage Army Combat Mindset developmental pathway.

Stage	Step	CMC contribution
1. Understand Self	Recognise your response.	Introduces self-awareness and understanding of individual responses to pressure.
2. Regulate Self	Control that response.	Develops practical regulation skills and the Combat Mindset Reset.
3. Perform Under Pressure	Sustain performance under pressure.	Progressively conditions those capacities under increasing and varied forms of load.
4. Combat Mindset	Apply it to operational demands.	Integrated into representative military training so the individual practises maintaining effective performance under increasingly realistic operational demands.

Product Architecture

The vocabulary nests the product inside the system and gives each element one job.

Layer	Element	Role
System	Army Combat Mindset System	The overarching Army training system.
Product	Combat Mindset Conditioning	The deliberate practice used to develop the capacity.
Element	Combat Mindset Training Pillars	What we develop.
Element	Combat Mindset Reset	How we restore performance when it drops.
Element	Combat Mindset Performance States	What effective performance looks like.
Element	CMC Training Methodology	How we progressively condition it under pressure.
Element	CMC Coaching and Assurance	How Army teaches, assesses and maintains the standard.
Outcome	Combat Mindset	The capacity to regulate and sustain effective performance under operational pressure.

This is the architecture to take into the next conversation with Ken Franks: not "we are renaming your product", but "here is how your proven architecture could translate into an Army-owned training product nested within the ACMS."

Sources and Status

Derived from the COGCON Phase 2 Discussion Document (Ken Franks) and the Army Combat Mindset System one-pager (Army Command School, 2026). Elements derived from COGCON are subject to adaptation and to the IP arrangements agreed with Ken Franks. Working terminology is proposed for discussion and is not yet locked. The Army design requirements above identify the elements Army still needs to design and endorse.